

Lament



SUMMARY

This lament is meant for the sea turtles aching to give birth, who, arriving at the shore where they breed each year, will lay their eggs in poisoned nests.

It's for the cormorant draped in funeral cloths, the shiny colors reflected in oil on the sand, the darkness spreading across the sea.

It's for the ocean that has been fatally tarnished. It's for Ahmed, who is unable to cross the border. It's for the soldier burned alive in his uniform.

It's for the people who make the weapons, and for the young rifleman who only signed up because he was lonely, and the farmer's boys, who only cared about getting to hear and play music.

And for the other sea turtles, the ones with curved beaks, and for sea mammals like dugongs and dolphins, and for the whale stunned into silence by the roar of missiles.

It's for the birds, too: the tern, the gull, the birds who wade in water, looking for food. It's for the migrations that are thrown off kilter, and the drawn-out deaths that occur as a result. It's for the hidden sun and the sharp smell of rage.

And it's for the earth that was scorched and the sun that disappeared in the smoke, for the burned ocean and the oil burning in wells. It's for retribution, and for the charred remains of language.

photograph in which an Iraqi soldier burned to death trying to escape his tank), and the young "fusilier" (or rifleman) who only joined up because he was lonely. Those who signed up for the war didn't all know what they were getting into, the poem implies, and war harms even those responsible for perpetrating its horrors. There are no winners when it comes to such immense violence, which burns everyone in its path.

- The poem also mourns "Ahmed at the closed border." "Ahmed" is a common name and, here, is likely a stand-in for the millions of refugees displaced by the violence. War's victims, the poem suggests, are often innocent bystanders.

It's not just *people* who suffered in the war, either, and "Lament" illustrates how humanity's impulse towards violence is devastating for *all* of earth's creatures:

- The speaker also mourns for "the green turtle" preparing to lay her "eggs" in a "nest of sickness" and the "cormorant" (a kind of seabird) "in his funeral silk." These images refer to the deliberate oil spill in which Iraqi troops dumped 400 million gallons of U.S. oil into the Persian Gulf, resulting in "a shadow on the sea" and leading to the deaths of many marine animals.
- The speaker also describes "the whale struck dumb by the missile's thunder" and seabirds likewise disoriented and doomed to die from the disruption to their natural habitat.

Finally, the poem emphasizes that the earth itself was torn apart by the war:

- The speaker refers to the "burnt earth," alluding to Iraq's scorched-earth policy, in which they set oil fires to devastate the land when they were forced to pull out of Kuwait.
- The speaker also describes the sun as "veiled" from the smoke of these fires, and the "ocean" as "scalded" by them. The speaker shows that the war decimated every form of life possible; nothing was unscathed.

The poem ends with the speaker mourning "vengeance" itself, as well as "the ashes of language," suggesting that there is simply no way to make sense of, or justify, this scale of violence. "Language," here, might represent truth, meaning, or even our shared humanity—things that the poem argues war utterly decimates.



THEMES



THE HUMAN AND ENVIRONMENTAL COSTS OF WAR

Gillian Clarke's "Lament" is a song of mourning for those killed in or as a direct result of the Persian Gulf War (fought in 1990-1991 between 39 NATO members and Iraq, which had invaded Kuwait to take control of its oil reserves). As the poem describes the soldiers, civilians, animals, and natural environments that suffered in the conflict, it builds an argument against war in general. No part of life on earth—nor even the earth itself—is safe from the damage war causes.

"Lament" takes the form of a long list of the war's victims, making clear that no one and nothing was immune from its destruction:

- For example, the poem mourns both the "soldier with his uniform of fire" (a reference to a

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-21

**LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS****LINES 1-3**

*For the green ...
... nest of sickness.*

A "lament" is a song or expression of grief. Clarke's poem specifically mourns the grievous damage inflicted on people, animals, and the environment during the Persian Gulf War (fought between NATO and Iraq after Iraq invaded and occupied Kuwait). In particular, the poem addresses the effects of one of the worst oil spills in history, which occurred when Iraqi troops dumped 400 million gallons of U.S. oil into the Persian Gulf in an attempt to prevent U.S. troops from landing in Kuwait.

The speaker begins by mourning "the green turtle with her pulsing burden." In other words, this turtle is urgently looking for somewhere to lay her eggs. She is searching for a "breeding ground," the poem continues, before then offering this lament also to the turtle's "eggs laid in their nest of sickness."

Green turtles are a kind of sea turtle; already endangered before the war began, the oil spill impacted their ability to hatch healthy eggs. Beginning the poem with the turtles makes it immediately apparent that although human beings are the ones who wage wars, they aren't the only ones who must live with the consequences. The image of eggs being laid in poisoned sand also suggests the way future generations—whether animal or human—will continue to be shaped by the war's ecological damage. Hissing [sibilance](#) ("nest of sickness") helps to emphasize this devastating reality and also contributes to the poem's sorrowful and somber tone.

The repetition of "For" in lines 1 and 3 is an example of [anaphora](#). (The poem will in fact feature this device in every stanza, each of which begins with the phrase "For the.") This repetition emphasizes that this poem is being offered to the victims of the war—and that those victims are many.

LINES 4-6

*For the cormorant ...
... on the sea.*

In the second stanza, the speaker dedicates this lament to "the cormorant in his funeral silk." A "cormorant" is a kind of diving seabird, thousands of which were killed by the Persian Gulf oil spill. The bird's "funeral silk" is a [metaphor](#) for the oil coating its feathers, making it too heavy to fly and therefore killing it.

The speaker then describes "the veil of iridescence on the sand," another reference to the oil spill. In certain lights, oil

slicks appear shimmery and reflective; the sand looks like it's wearing a shimmery cloak. That same oil creates a "shadow on the sea": a large swath of darkness on the water.

These lines are thick with [sibilance](#) ("silk," "iridescence," "sand," "sea"), which casts a somber hush over the poem while also subtly evoking the smooth, slippery movement of that oil across the landscape.

This stanza also picks up on the [anaphora](#) of the first, again beginning with the phrase "For the." Lines 5 and 6 then both begin with "the":

*For the cormorant in his funeral silk,
the veil [...]
the shadow [...]*

Anaphora makes this list of the war's victims feel relentless. [Asyndeton](#) adds to the effect: there are no coordinating conjunctions between the items on this list, which makes it sound like the speaker could simply go on and on—that these are just a few of countless examples.

LINES 7-9

*For the ocean's ...
... uniform of fire.*

The poem next mourns the "ocean's lap with its mortal stain." Like the "shadow on the sea" in the previous stanza, this is a [metaphor](#) for the appearance of the oil spill on the water. The word "lap" can be read two ways here:

- On one level, it subtly [personifies](#) the ocean as a figure whose "lap" is stained with oil. It's as though the ocean's life force is slowly leaking out of it; it has been mortally wounded.
- "Lap" can also refer to the movement of the ocean's waves against the shore. Its blackened water washes up, spreading the oil and, it follows, death.

In line 8, the speaker moves from lamenting the destruction of the natural world to describing the people victimized by the war. This poem, the speaker continues, is "For Ahmed at the closed border." "Ahmed" likely represents one of the millions of refugees—from both Kuwait and Iraq—who fled, or tried to flee, during the war. In the poem, a border closure prevents Ahmed person from escaping, illustrating how regular civilians may be trapped in horrific situations by political circumstances beyond their control.

Of course, the war also harms those actively fighting in it. In line 9, the speaker mourns "The soldier with his uniform of fire": an [allusion](#) to a famous photograph of an Iraqi soldier who burned to death trying to escape from his tank. This image is a reminder of the violent reality of war, which consumes everything in its path. Though people in power declare war, it is

ordinary people who must fight and pay the steepest consequences.

LINES 10-12

*For the gunsmith ...
... for the music.*

The speaker continues to mourn the war's human victims. Perhaps surprisingly to readers, the poem extends its sympathies even toward those making and supplying weapons. The poem suggests that some soldiers were too young to understand precisely what they were signing up for. The poem calls the "fusilier" (or rifleman) a "boy," for example, who "joined" the troops because he wanted to make (or perhaps follow in the footsteps of) friends. He didn't want to hurt people; he wanted "company."

The mention of "farmer's sons" further hammers home the *humanity* of those fighting. They are someone's children, and they can also be victims of propaganda, poverty, and political machinations in which they have no real say. Indeed, the speaker declares that these "sons" were "in it for the music." "Music," here, evokes the seductive promise of camaraderie, patriotism, and perhaps even adventure that these young men were drawn to.

The fact that they were "farmer's sons" might also suggest that for young people, especially those from impoverished or isolated rural communities, enlisting can feel like an opportunity to get out and experience something or better their circumstances. Again, the poem emphasizes that wars are waged by governments but fought by regular people.

LINES 13-15

*For the hook-beaked ...
... the missile's thunder.*

The list of the war's casualties continues, with the poem returning its attention to the natural world. The speaker now grieves "the hook-beaked turtles," most likely a description of the hawksbill turtle (another species of sea turtle impacted by the oil spill). They also mourn sea mammals such as "the dugong" (a creature similar to a manatee) "and the dolphin," as well as "the whale struck dumb by the missile's thunder."

In these lines, thudding /d/ [alliteration](#) ("dugong," "dolphin," "dumb") and [consonance](#) ("thunder") evoked the low boom of bombs and guns, the sounds of which can disorient creatures who rely on echolocation to navigate the depths of the sea, communicate with each other, and find food. (Hence why those whales are "struck dumb," unable to [metaphorically](#) "speak.") The humming /m/ consonance of "dumb"/"missile" and the blunt [assonance](#) of "struck dumb [...] thunder" also subtly mirroring the muffled sound of artillery from under water.

LINES 16-18

For the tern, ...

... stink of anger.

In the sixth stanza, the poem moves from under the sea back to the ocean's surface. The speaker mourns seabirds such as the "tern" and "gull," who swoop down to the water to fish, as well as the "wader," a kind of bird that finds sustenance in the shallow waters near the shore. In poisoning the water and land, the oil spill destroyed the birds' food supply. Unsafe and hungry, these birds flew great distances to find food and shelter—undertaking "long migrations" only to often die of starvation and exhaustion along the way. Their deaths, the poem implies, were cruelly "slow."

The poem then laments "the veiled sun and the stink of anger." The "veiled sun" is a reference to the fact that smoke from oil fires literally blocked sunlight for a time in Kuwait. The "stink of anger," meanwhile, is likely a [metaphor](#) for the stench of burning oil. It also might be a nod to the many years of unrest and complicated political turmoil that followed the war—and, indeed, continue to this day. On a figurative level, the phrase suggests that human rage lingers like a terrible stench.

As in previous stanzas, [anaphora](#) and [parallelism](#) become the beat to this slow, sad, funereal song:

**For the tern, the gull, and the restless wader,
the long migrations and the slow dying,
the veiled sun and the stink of anger.**

The intense [sibilance](#) here also begins to conjure the speaker's feelings of frustration and even "anger." The lines hiss out as though through gritted teeth.

LINES 19-21

*For the burnt ...
... ashes of language.*

So far, the poem has mourned the animals, human beings, and natural environments marred by war. In the poem's final stanza, the speaker zooms out to lament the destruction of the earth itself. This violence touches *everything*, the poem asserts, scorching the earth, blotting out the sun, and burning the ocean.

The [imagery](#) here is downright hellish and meant to evoke the horror and devastation of war in general. It also [alludes](#) to the specifics of the Gulf War:

- U.S. air strikes were meant to minimize harm to U.S. troops and their allies (indeed, around 300 of the coalition's troops were killed as opposed to 8,000-10,000 Iraqi troops), but the result was immense environmental damage to Kuwait, where the war was fought.
- Iraqi attempts to sabotage U.S. troops by spilling their oil into the sea led to one of the worst ecological disasters in history. As the oil burned, it

"scalded" the ocean.

- Moreover, when Iraq retreated from Kuwait, troops set 700 oil wells on fire out of spite.
- Clouds of smoke from all this burning oil "put out the sun"—in Kuwait, quite literally: skies darkened and temperatures dropped for weeks.

In the final line of the poem, the speaker laments the human capacity for "vengeance." The desire for revenge and retribution is utterly self-destructive, and, the poem implies, will cost humanity everything. Indeed, the last thing the speaker grieves is "the ashes of language," a [metaphor](#) suggesting there is no "language" that can explain or justify war's cost. This metaphor also suggests that war destroys humanity itself: after all, language is what allows us to create culture and art and to talk through our differences. Clarke herself has said that the death of language here refers to the death of "truth," something that is lost in the search for "vengeance."



SYMBOLS

FIRE/BURNING



The poem returns to images of flames and burning throughout. Much of this fire is literal, but it also represents the way that war [symbolically](#) destroys—burns through—everything it touches.

In the third stanza, for example, the speaker mentions a soldier "with his uniform of fire." This is a reference to an actual photograph of an Iraqi soldier covered in flames, but the image takes on broader symbolic significance in the context of the poem. To be dressed in a "uniform of flames" hints that such destruction is the recognizable trademark of war and that war's horrors *consume* all who fight in it.

The poem then mentions "the burnt earth," "the scalded ocean," and the "blazing well" in its final stanza. These images refer to the environmental damage caused by the war, but, together, they convey war's potential to destroy the entire planet. War even burns "language," the speaker says in the poem's final lines. This implies that war's horror is so great it destroys our capacity to communicate—to create art and culture, and to talk to each other like human beings.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Line 9:** "For the soldier with his uniform of fire."
- **Lines 19-20:** "For the burnt earth and the sun put out, / the scalded ocean and the blazing well."
- **Line 21:** "the ashes of language."



THE NEST OF SICKNESS

In the first stanza, the speaker describes a "green turtle" looking for a place to lay her eggs. The breeding ground has been terribly polluted by the fighting and oil spill, however, and the speaker thus mourns the fact that those eggs must be laid in a "nest of sickness."

This polluted "nest" might [symbolize](#) the way war's effects linger long into the future, impacting generations to come. Those eggs almost certainly won't hatch or survive; likewise, the poem suggests, people can't grow or truly thrive in a society devastated by conflict.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Line 3:** "For her eggs laid in their nest of sickness."



THE ASHES OF LANGUAGE

In the poem's final stanza, the speaker laments "the ashes of language." War is so devastating, this phrase implies, that it destroys even our ability to *describe* its horrors. More broadly, being able to speak is part of what makes us human; language is what allows us to create culture, art, and so on. It's also what would allow us to talk through issues with other nations rather than launching into violence. The image of language dwindled to dead, useless "ashes" thus [symbolizes](#) the way that war destroys our humanity itself.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Line 21:** "the ashes of language"



POETIC DEVICES

ANAPHORA

Almost every line "Lament" features [anaphora](#). Each stanza begins with the phrase "For the": "For the green turtle," "For the cormorant," "For the ocean's lap," and so on. This insistent repetition never lets readers forget what this poem is: a song of mourning "for" the victims of war. This anaphora makes the poem sound more dramatic, creating a relentless, inescapable rhythm that evokes war's inescapable violence.

Every line except for line 2 also begins with "for" or "the." For example, here's the second stanza:

For the cormorant in his funeral silk,
the veil of iridescence on the sand,
the shadow on the sea.

Again, this anaphora fills the poem with a powerful, driving rhythm. The list of war's victims seems to go on and on, and

anaphora helps to hammer home just how many different *kinds* of life were damaged or destroyed and how massive war's reach can be. Anaphora further establishes a sense of connection between civilians, soldiers, land animals, sea animals, and the environment: all of these things, the poem insists, were affected by the fighting.

The use of [asyndeton](#) throughout the poem works alongside anaphora to create the sense that this list is never-ending. Without any coordinating conjunctions, it feels as though this list could continue indefinitely. These are simply a few examples of many.

Where Anaphora appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "For the"
- **Line 3:** "For"
- **Line 4:** "For the"
- **Line 5:** "the"
- **Line 6:** "the"
- **Line 7:** "For the"
- **Line 8:** "For"
- **Line 9:** "For the"
- **Line 10:** "For the"
- **Line 11:** "the"
- **Line 12:** "the"
- **Line 13:** "For the"
- **Line 14:** "the"
- **Line 15:** "the"
- **Line 16:** "For the"
- **Line 17:** "the"
- **Line 18:** "the"
- **Line 19:** "For the"
- **Line 20:** "the"
- **Line 21:** "For"

METAPHOR

The poem's [metaphors](#) help to convey the horror and extent of war's devastation.

In the second stanza, for example, the speaker describes a "cormorant" (a kind of seabird) "in his funeral silk." This is a metaphor for the oil released into the sea during the and which now coats the bird's feathers: the slick, "silk[y]" oil would weigh the bird down and kill him, hence the idea that he is dressed like he's at his "funeral." The mention of the "veil of iridescence on the sand" in the next line is another reference to the oil spill: oil can appear shimmery and iridescent in certain lights.

That oil is also what casts "the shadow on the sea" and creates a "mortal stain" on "the ocean's lap." This last metaphor can be read in a few ways:

- The speaker may be [personifying](#) the ocean as a figure with a "lap" that's marked by the "mortal stain" of that oil. It's as though the ocean had been

stabbed and is now bleeding to death.

- "Lap" also refers to the motion of waves against the shore, so the speaker might be describing how the dark oil spreads through the water, killing everything it touches.
- Both readings emphasize that the planet is a living creature wounded by humanity's violence.

The poem uses another metaphor in the mention of a "uniform of fire." This refers to a real photograph of an Iraqi soldier covered in flames. Referring to those flames as his "uniform," however, creates a striking image that suggests an inextricable link between the military/war and devastation. Though the image is real, it also becomes [symbolic](#) of the way in which war metaphorically *burns* everything it touches.

Indeed, much of the poem's imagery and metaphors revolved around flame and burning: there's the "scalded ocean and the blazing well," for example, as well as "the ashes of language." All of this emphasizes war's immensely destructive potential. Its horrors are so great that they can't even be described in language, which gets burned up along with the "earth" and the "ocean."

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 3:** "For her eggs laid in their nest of sickness."
- **Line 4:** "For the cormorant in his funeral silk"
- **Lines 5-6:** "the veil of iridescence on the sand, / the shadow on the sea."
- **Line 7:** "For the ocean's lap with its mortal stain"
- **Line 9:** "For the soldier with his uniform of fire."
- **Line 15:** "the whale struck dumb by the missile's thunder."
- **Line 18:** "the veiled sun and the stink of anger"
- **Line 21:** "the ashes of language"

CONSONANCE

[Consonance](#) appears throughout "Lament," making its language sound more dramatic and intense.

Some of this consonance is also an example of [alliteration](#). In the first two lines, for example, /b/ alliteration highlights the words "burden" and "breeding." This draws attention to the way the war affected wild animals and their young. This implies that the effects of war aren't just immediate: they harm future generations as well.

In lines 14-15, the poem uses alliteration and consonance again as the speaker lists out some of the sea mammals harmed by the Gulf War:

the dugong and the dolphin,
the whale struck dumb by the missile's thunder.

These thudding /d/ and /m/ sounds call to mind the muffled boom of missiles underwater. [Assonance](#) ("struck dumb [...] thunder") the language more intense still, highlighting this devastating image of "whales," which rely on echolocation to navigate underwater, unable to speak ("dumb").

[Sibilance](#) appears a few times in the poem as well, adding to its serious and mournful [tone](#). Take the slick /s/ sounds in lines 4-6, which evoke the slippery, shimmering oil the poem describes:

For the cormorant in his funeral silk,
the veil of iridescence in the sand,
the shadow on the sea.

Towards the end of the poem, the hissing, threatening sibilance of "sun" and "stink" hint at the speaker's own "anger" at the devastation humanity has wrought.

Where Consonance appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "burden"
- **Line 2:** "breeding"
- **Line 3:** "eggs," "nest," "sickness"
- **Line 4:** "silk"
- **Line 5:** "iridescence," "sand"
- **Line 6:** "shadow," "sea"
- **Line 7:** "ocean's," "stain"
- **Line 9:** "uniform," "fire"
- **Line 14:** "dugong," "dolphin"
- **Line 15:** "dumb," "missile's," "thunder"
- **Line 18:** "sun," "stink"
- **Line 19:** "burnt"
- **Line 20:** "scalded," "ocean," "blazing"
- **Line 21:** "vengeance," "ashes"

IMAGERY

"Lament" relies on stark, vivid [imagery](#) to portray the horrors of war.

The poem is filled with images of darkness, death, and suffering. For example, in the first stanza, the speaker describes "the green turtle with her pulsing burden" who is forced to lay her eggs on the poisoned seashore. The phrase "pulsing burden" suggests the urgency of giving birth; this turtle doesn't have time to go in search of safer places to deposit her young, so she returns to the [metaphorical](#) "nest of sickness" (that is, an area destroyed by the oil spill).

In lines 4-6, the speaker describes the effect of the Gulf War oil spill on seabirds like the "cormorant," whose body, slick with oil, looks like it's cloaked with a funeral shroud. This same oil coats the surface of the ocean and the shore, casting a "veil of iridescence" on the sand and a "shadow on the sea." In the last two stanzas, the imagery is even more stripped down and blunt, with the speaker describing "the veiled" (or hidden) "sun and

the stink of anger," "the burnt earth and the sun put out," and "the scalded ocean and the blazing well." Smoke from burning oil blots out the sun and its stench fills the air, an inescapable reminder of the "vengeance" that led to all this destruction. War, all this imagery insists, tears across the landscape, devouring everything in its path.

Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "For the green turtle with her pulsing burden"
- **Lines 4-6:** "For the cormorant in his funeral silk, / the veil of iridescence on the sand, / the shadow on the sea."
- **Line 7:** "For the ocean's lap with its mortal stain."
- **Line 9:** "For the soldier with his uniform of fire."
- **Line 15:** "the whale struck dumb by the missile's thunder."
- **Lines 18-20:** "the veiled sun and the stink of anger. / For the burnt earth and the sun put out, / the scalded ocean and the blazing well."



VOCABULARY

Cormorant (Line 4) - A kind of seabird.

Iridescence (Line 5) - The appearance of a rainbow-like spectrum of colors on a lustrous surface (such as an oil stain).

Ahmed (Lines 7-8) - An Arabic masculine name, common in the Middle East (the poem's [setting](#)).

Gunsmith (Line 10) - A person who makes guns.

Armourer (Line 10) - A person or company that makes, supplies, or repairs weaponry.

Boy fusilier (Line 11) - A young rifleman.

Hook-beaked turtles (Line 13) - Sea turtles.

Dugong (Line 14) - A marine mammal closely related to the manatee.

Tern (Line 16) - A kind of seabird.

Restless wader (Line 16) - Probably a description of seabirds that stick to shallow water to hunt for food.

Blazing well (Line 20) - Here referring to a burning oil well. (During the Gulf War, Iraqi forces set hundreds of Kuwaiti oil wells on fire.)



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Lament" consists of 21 lines of [free verse](#) arranged into seven tercets, or three-line [stanzas](#). Its structure also uses a great deal of [anaphora](#). The [repetition](#) of initial words/phrases (e.g., every stanza begins with "For the") gives the poem a

consistency that underscores its purpose: to mourn what's been hurt or lost.

The arrangement also makes the poem feel song-like—slow and orderly, like a funeral march. Although "Lament" can certainly be read as a warning about the cost of war in general, it's also a marker of losses that have already happened, a lament for the consequences of this specific war. The stanzas divide the roll call of losses into short units, giving readers a little room to process the massive damage the speaker is describing.

METER

The poem is written in [free verse](#), so it doesn't follow any set [meter](#). The absence of meter makes the language sound more direct (though not necessarily conversational or loose, since the constant use of [anaphora](#) gives the poem a song-like structure). And while meter could have contributed to the poem's musicality, it might also have distracted from the stark ugliness of the poem's subject: war and its consequences.

The poem's spare quality adds to the horror of its images, such as a soldier burning to death and animals dying from an oil-poisoned environment. In other words, avoiding meter helps the poem depict war in a fairly blunt, straightforward way, without sounding excessively "poetic."

RHYME SCHEME

The poem is written in [free verse](#), so it doesn't use a [rhyme scheme](#). Most contemporary poetry is written using free verse, which allows the poet great flexibility and tends to produce a more natural, conversational rhythm. Like [meter](#), a rhyme scheme creates intense musicality. Here, that effect might have distracted from the poem's spare, yet poignant depiction of war and its consequences. As the speaker confronts the stark reality of the Persian Gulf War—including all the destruction and death it caused—the language remains relatively stark to match.



SPEAKER

The speaker of "Lament" has no real presence in the poem. By essentially removing the speaker from the poem, Clarke keeps the focus entirely on the victims of the Persian Gulf War. That is, the poem is laser-focused on who this "lament" is *for*—not who is doing the lamenting.



SETTING

"Lament" takes place in the aftermath of the Persian Gulf War, which was primarily fought in Kuwait and southern Iraq from 1990-1991. The poem's horrific [imagery](#) conveys the war's devastating impact on the environment, which was the result of both the fighting in general and Iraqi troops' deliberate

destruction of the region: troops dumped 400 million gallons of oil into the Persian Gulf and set hundreds of oil wells aflame, creating clouds of smoke so thick they temporarily "put out" the sun in Kuwait.

The poem [alludes](#) to all this with its references to birds too slick with oil to fly, a turtle forced to lay her eggs in poisoned sand, and marine mammals "struck dumb" by the boom of missiles. The poem describes how the oil casts a dark "shadow" on the sea, as though the water has been mortally wounded, and makes the "sand" iridescent. As the oil burns atop the Gulf, the water appears "scalded," and oil wells are "blazing" across the land. The poem's setting is thus one of terrifying darkness, chaos, and death.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Born in Cardiff in 1937, poet, playwright, and translator Gillian Clarke is one of the most recognizable names in contemporary Welsh poetry. Clarke spent eight years serving as the National Poet of Wales, from 2008-2016. "Lament" was published in Clarke's 1997 *Collected Poems* and responds to events of the 1990-1991 Persian Gulf War. Of the poem, Clarke has written:

War can't be waged without grave damage to every aspect of life. All the details in the poem came from reports in the media. There were newspaper photographs of cormorants covered with oil—"in his funeral silk." 'The veil of iridescence on the sand' and 'the shadow on the sea' show the spreading stain of oil from bombed oil wells. The burning oil seemed to put the sun out, and poisoned the land and the sea. The 'boy fusilier who joined for the company,' and 'the farmer's sons, in it for the music,' came from hearing radio interviews with their mothers. The creatures were listed by Friends of the Earth as being at risk of destruction by oil pollution, and 'the soldier in his uniform of fire' was a horrific photograph of a soldier burnt when his tank was bombed. The ashes of language are the death of truth during war.

Clarke names English Romantic poet [William Wordsworth](#), Irish poets [William Butler Yeats](#) and [Seamus Heaney](#), and fellow Welsh poet [Dylan Thomas](#) as major influences on her work. She is also friends with fellow contemporary British poets [Carol Ann Duffy](#), [Jackie Kay](#), and [Imtiaz Dharker](#).

"Lament" is one of many poems describing the terrible consequences of war on the environment. Other poems in this vein include Linda Hogan's "[Song for the Turtles in the Gulf](#)," which also addresses the impact of the Gulf War oil spill, "[To](#)

[Our Land](#)" by Mahmoud Darwish, and "[At the Bomb Testing Site](#)" by William Stafford.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

In August of 1990, Iraq's president, Saddam Hussein, ordered the invasion and occupation of Kuwait in an effort to expand Iraqi power by taking control of Kuwait's oil reserves. He assumed that surrounding Arab nations would support his invasion, but instead, Saudi Arabia and Kuwait's exiled leaders turned to the United States and NATO (the North Atlantic Treaty Organization) to condemn Iraq's aggression.

When Hussein refused the UN's demand to withdraw from Kuwait by the middle of January the following year, the Persian Gulf War began. The U.S. led a persistent air offensive, using the latest military technology to quickly eradicate Iraqi resistance. President H.W. Bush declared a ceasefire in February of 1991, which ended the war.

"Lament" foregrounds the effects of the war on the environment, which are still apparent over three decades later. Sea turtles were already considered an endangered species before Iraqi troops, in an effort to keep U.S. troops from landing in Kuwait, intentionally dumped 400 million gallons of U.S. oil into the Gulf. Considered an act of eco-terrorism, this spill had devastating consequences. The Center for Biological Diversity estimates that it resulted in the death or harm of tens of thousands of birds, fish, sea turtles, and marine mammals, while also devastating beaches and marshes.

famous photograph from the Gulf War (which Clarke references in line 9). (<https://www.theatlantic.com/international/archive/2014/08/the-war-photo-no-one-would-publish/375762/>)

- [The Catastrophic Damage From Oil Spills](#) — An article from the Ocean Foundation on the effects of the Persian Gulf oil spill as well as the consequences of oil spills on the environment more generally. (<https://oceanfdn.org/the-catastrophic-damages-from-oil-spills/>)
- [The Poet's Notes on "Lament"](#) — Gillian Clarke provides some explanation for her poem. (<http://www.gillianclarke.co.uk/gc2017/notes-lament/>)
- [An Introduction to the Poet's Work](#) — Read a biography of Gillian Clark from Poetry International. (https://www.poetryinternational.com/en/poets-poems/poets/poet/102-18864_Clarke)
- [More About the Persian Gulf War](#) — Check out a brief chronology of the events leading up to the war and learn more about how it was fought. (<https://www.history.com/topics/middle-east/persian-gulf-war>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER GILLIAN CLARKE POEMS

- [Catrin](#)



HOW TO CITE

MLA

Mottram, Darla. "Lament." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 26 Jul 2023. Web. 31 Jul 2023.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Mottram, Darla. "Lament." LitCharts LLC, July 26, 2023. Retrieved July 31, 2023. <https://www.litcharts.com/poetry/gillian-clarke/lament>.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [The Longterm Impact of the Oil Spill](https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2021/dec/11/the-sound-of-roaring-fires-is-still-in-my-memory-30-years-on-from-kuwaits-oil-blazes) — A 2021 Guardian article about the continued ramifications of the oil spill for Kuwait. (<https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2021/dec/11/the-sound-of-roaring-fires-is-still-in-my-memory-30-years-on-from-kuwaits-oil-blazes>)
- [The War Photo No One Would Publish](#) — The story of a